

Fresh- and saltwater

The Earth is often called the blue planet because 75 percent of its surface is covered in water. Most of the Earth's water is saltwater in the oceans. Less than one percent of all the water on the Earth is fresh.



The hydrosphere

The hydrosphere is the name for all the water on the Earth. It includes oceans, rivers, and lakes. It also includes water that is frozen, such as icebergs.

Freshwater sources

People get freshwater from different sources on the Earth's surface, including rivers, streams, lakes, and reservoirs.



Rivers and streams flow from mountains down to the oceans.



Lakes are natural dips in the Earth where water collects.



Reservoirs are man-made lakes that are built to store water.



Water for life

All living things must have water to survive. In mammals, including humans, water is part of the blood and of organs, such as the skin and brain. There is water in every cell in your body. In fact, cells contain about two-thirds of the body's water!

Trapped in ice

Less than 33 percent of freshwater is usable by humans. The rest is frozen in glaciers or icebergs (below) or as huge sheets of ice at the North and South poles.

